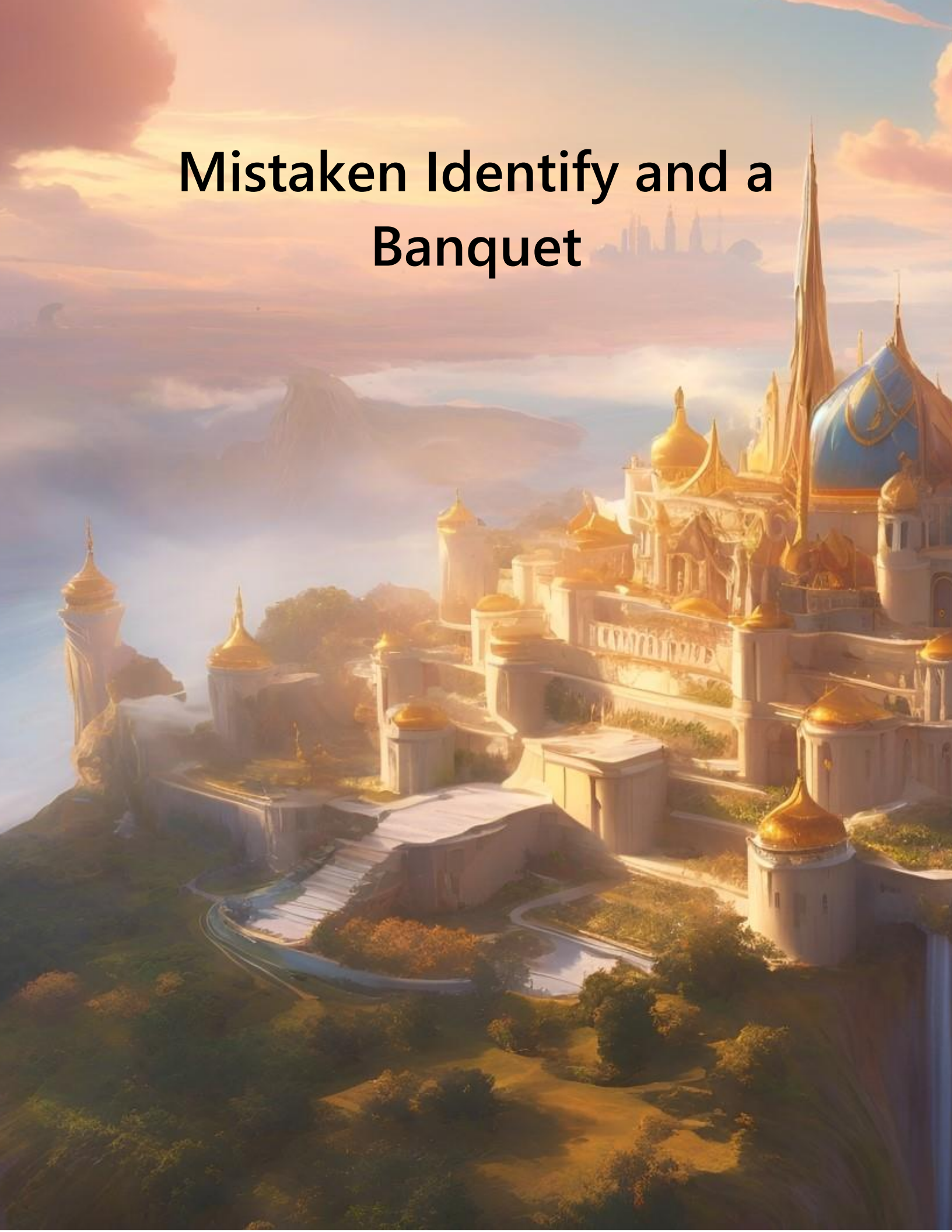
Mistaken Identify and a Banquet



Mistaken Identify and a Banquet

Winds of Betrayal: Shadows in the Citadel of Ice and Steel

Introduction: Prepare to embark on a journey into the elemental city, the Citadel of Ice and Steel. Your players will unravel deceit, treachery, and an elemental cult as they navigate the floating metropolis. With an enigmatic heist in the background, hidden secrets near a Djinn noble, and the menacing presence of the Howling Hatred cult. As they untangle the threads of the narrative, they'll delve into a world rich with elemental lore, enigmatic NPCs, and unique challenges, all set against the backdrop of a city suspended in perpetual freefall. Are your players ready to uncover the mysteries lurking in the skies and bring evil cultists to justice?

A Four-hour adventure for 1st-4th level characters

by Aaron Smith

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The Invitation



Suddenly, a hushed whisper of arcane magic ripples near the group, followed by the subtle chime of a tuning fork. You turn to see a flicking white and blue magical gate materialize before you.

Emerging gracefully from the shimmering portal is an aarakocra, resembling a vibrant cardinal in both appearance and stature. He extends a polite wing in greeting, his beady eyes glittering with intelligence.

At first the aarakocra speaks to the players in Auran. If no one responds, he switches to Common.

"Greetings, travelers," he chirps in a melodic voice. "I am Zephyrus, a humble servant of a Djinn noble Azurith of the enigmatic Citadel of Ice and Steel. My master extends a gracious invitation to you, esteemed guests, for a forthcoming celebratory banquet."

Zephyrus delicately unfurls a small, intricately patterned envelope and offers it to your group. The envelope is adorned with intricate designs that seem to dance and shift, capturing your attention. He continues, "Please, accept this invitation, and you shall find yourselves transported to the main portal gate of the Citadel in one tenday. Do wear formal attire, for the occasion calls for it."

He pauses for a moment, a glimmer of concern flashing in his avian eyes. "One thing, however," Zephyrus adds cautiously, "the magic within the envelope is a one-time use. I implore you not to open it prematurely, as it will only activate when our gracious host welcomes his esteemed guests."

Zephyrus, dressed in the regal attire befitting a servant of a noble, awaits your response.

A DC 15 Insight (Wisdom) check may reveal that the aarakocra is not entirely truthful about the nature of the envelope. Opening it early or after the banquet's conclusion will not activate the magic but will reveal an invitation to another group of adventurers.

A casting of detect magic on the envelope reveals an aura of conjuration magic.

Reading the Invitation Early

If the characters open the envelope early, the text within the invitation reads:

To the Esteemed Heroes Lady Grimora Stonefist, Mistress Sylva Mischiefwhistle, Sir Thrain Ironbeard, Master Aiden Shadowblade, and Lord Elaris Thornebow,

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In the esteemed presence of Djinn noble Azurith the Magnificent, you are cordially invited to partake in a grand celebration near the Citadel of Ice and Steel. Your exceptional valor in recovering The Scepter of Zephyrion has earned participation in the annual celebratory banquet.

This gathering will take place one tenday from now. During the party, this envelope will take you to the main portal gate of the citadel. A coach will take you from the gate to the palace.

The attire of the utmost formality is requested, as befitting the splendor of this occasion. Please present this invitation upon your arrival, for it is the key to your passage. The envelope shall activate its magic only when guests are welcome to arrive.

We eagerly anticipate your presence and in recognition of your bravery. You shall be delighted in this splendid evening.

With great anticipation,
Azurith the Magnificent

If the players wait until the appointed time to open the envelope. The invitation shines with blue and white light and the players will be unable to read it.

Getting Ready

The characters have a tenday to prepare for the grand banquet, which includes various tasks to ensure they are ready for the festivities. One of the key preparations is acquiring formal attire, as they must adhere to the dress code for the occasion.

As you accept the invitation from Zephyrus, you realize that you have precisely a tenday to prepare for the upcoming grand banquet at the Citadel of Ice and Steel. The tasks ahead are twofold, and the clock is ticking.

1. Formal Attire: The invitation clearly states that formal attire is expected at the celebration. If you already possess suitable garments, you're one step ahead. However, if you lack the appropriate clothing, you'll need to find or acquire it within the tenday. The palace will be opulent, so your attire should match the grandeur of the event.

2. Banquet Preparations: Aside from attire, you should also consider any other preparations you might need for travelling on another plane. Perhaps there are items or spells you wish to acquire, or information you want to gather about the Citadel, its inhabitants, or the Djinn noble himself. It would be a good idea to be able to speak or at least understand Auran.

What is Going On

Eleven months ago, Howling Hatred cultist stole the Scepter of Zephyrion from Azurith's palace. They did this by bribing Zephyrus to steal the scepter and deliver it to them in the Citadel of Ice and Steel. Azurith hired a group of adventurers to recover the scepter. The heroes followed the cultist to a windswept mountain near the Dessarin Valley and defeated the Howling Hatred Priest in charge of a clandestine safe house. The heroes triumphantly returned the scepter to Azurith and took a short vacation in the Citadel of Ice and Steel. The cultists blackmailed Zephyrus. Under the cultists' coercion, Zephyrus lured the heroes into a trap, where the cultists murdered the adventurers.

Not knowing the fate of the heroes, Azurith instructs Zephyrus to invite them to his annual celebratory banquet. Desperate not to get caught, Zephyrus invited the first group of adventurers on the Material Plane he could find. Zephyrus, however, knows well that Azurith's eyes cannot discern the true heroes from the newcomers, for in his eyes, "All mudwalkers look the same." Zephyrus will try to keep the players away from Azurith, and usher them out of the palace as early as possible. If the party misbehaves or if he gets desperate, Zephyrus will accuse the players of some crime and have security escort the players to a coach or subdue the players.

Guests assume that the players are the heroes.

Heroes of Zephyrion

Match the players to the heroes as best as you can.

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- Grimora Stonefist, Female Half-Orc Champion Fighter
- Sylva Mischiefwhistle, Female Gnome Illusion Wizard
- Thrain Ironbeard, Male Dwarf Cleric of Light
- Aiden Shadowblade, Male Human Rogue Thief
- Elaris Thornebow, Male Wood Half-Elf Horizon-Walker Ranger

Traveling to the palace



As the appointed time arrives and the players open the patterned invitation.

A sudden and enchanting sensation washes over you. The air fills with the harmonious hum of a tuning fork, and before your eyes, a flickering, mesmerizing blue and white light emerges, swirling and expanding to form a ten-foot diameter circular portal.

Stepping through the portal, you find yourselves standing just outside the massive gate of the Citadel of Ice and Steel. The grand citadel looms before them, its towering walls glistening with icy elegance, while steel structures rise like sentinels against the azure sky.

But their attention is quickly drawn as a voice calls out in Auran, from behind and to the right. Characters who cannot understand Auran do not understand the coach driver.

"You must be the esteemed mudwalkers from the Material Planes," says a female air genasi. She motions for you to step onto a magnificent coach that hovers above the icy ground. The carriage has no wheels but floats gracefully, pulled by a pair of majestic, white-winged griffons.

Outside the citadel's walls, a line of similar coaches awaits, all poised to transport guests to Azurith's majestic palace.

As your journey to the palace begins, you are treated to breathtaking aerial views of the Citadel of Ice and Steel. However, the serenity is short-lived as a dark and foreboding storm cloud materializes with alarming speed. Lightning arcs through the skies, followed by thunderous claps that reverberate through the very marrow of your bones.

The blinding flashes of lightning and deafening roars of thunder surround the carriage, and all players need to roll two saving throws.

- DC 10 Constitution saving throw or be deafened by the storm.
- DC 10 Constitution saving throw to avoid being temporarily blinded by the lightning.

These effects persist for two minutes.

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The tumultuous weather spooks the griffons, causing them to buck the carriage. The players must now roll to stay within the coach.

DC 15 Athletics (Strength) or DC 15 Acrobatics (Dexterity) check to stay within the coach.

Failure results in being thrown from the carriage.

The coach driver, now both blind and deaf, struggles to regain control of the situation. The players can attempt to take control of the coach.

DC 15 Animal Handling (Wisdom) check to calm the griffons and steer the coach back on course.

If control is not reestablished, the griffons will eventually settle down after two additional checks made by all players. Players who fall from the carriage, fall for 100 feet and then begin to hover. The coach driver easily brings the carriage around to retrieve the fallen players. The coach driver is visibly embarrassed if any players fall out.

Players may take a short rest while riding to Azurith's palace.

Azurith's Palace



The players' journey through the tempestuous skies eventually leads them to a sight that takes their breath away. Perched majestically upon a hovering island is the resplendent palace of Azurith, surrounded by a sprawling ranch devoted to the training and care of griffons.

As you prepare to disembark from your magnificent coach, your eyes take in the sprawling ranch. It's a bustling hub of activity, where stables, pens, and soaring perches are scattered across the fertile terrain. Griffons of various sizes and colors roam, train, and take flight, showcasing a remarkable display of grace and power. The air is filled with the resonant calls and melodic cries of these majestic creatures.

The significance of this ranch becomes apparent—the source of Azurith's wealth lies in the breeding, raising, and training of griffons, which serve both as steeds and essential beasts of burden in the skies.

As the coach lands on the floating earth mote, an aarakocra clad in impeccable formal attire approaches. His attire exudes an air of regality, befitting a servant of Azurith.

With a graceful bow of his avian head, he greets the party in Auran.

"Welcome, honored guests," with a mixture of reverence and warmth. He motions for the players to follow him, inviting them to enter the palace and partake in the grandeur that awaits within.

Enter Azurith's Palace

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As you pass through the towering gates of Azurith's palace, you find yourselves in a world of enchantment and wonder. The palace is perched on a floating earth mote, several miles away from the imposing Citadel of Ice and Steel. It is a breathtaking sight, suspended in the vast expanse of the Elemental Plane of Air.

The air around you is filled with a symphony of perfumes, an array of scents that twirl and mingle in a harmonious dance. It's a fragrant cacophony that envelops your senses as you step further into the palace grounds. Each perfume is unique, a reflection of the many guests in attendance.

The guests themselves are a diverse and exotic assembly of beings, embodying the essence of the Elemental Plane of Air. Djinni, with their resplendent forms, converse animatedly with one another. Air elementals, who are usually invisible, have pulled dust and smoke into themselves to be seen, some even donning formal attire for the occasion.

Aarakocra guests perch gracefully above, their feathered wings shining in the light. Air genasi, with their windswept hair and airy demeanor, mingle with other guests. Dust devils swirl playfully in corners, while invisible stalkers navigate the crowd, their presence known only by the occasional shimmer in the air.

The more diminutive guests, such as pixies, sprites, and fairies, flit about, adding an ethereal charm to the gathering. Among the guests, you spot an aasimar and a dragonborn, their celestial and metallic dragon heritage making them stand out.

But perhaps the most intriguing sight is the air elemental band. Musicians that are nearly invisible play an array of wind instruments, their melodies weaving through the atmosphere. Their instruments appear to float and move independently.



The elementals do not partake in the wine and hors d'oeuvres. Elemental creatures, who do not require

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sustenance, are attending purely for the enjoyment of the festivities.



As you take in this mesmerizing tableau, you can't help but feel a sense of anticipation in the air. The partyis in full swing, yet the host, Azurith, to not to be seen. The guests continue to chat, sharing stories and laughter, while the enchanting music of the air elemental band drifts on the breeze.

Encounters While Mingling

While waiting for Azurith to make his grand entrance the players can have several encounters with partygoers. Select or roll as many encounters as you wish.

Overhear Rumors About the Heroes of Zephyrion

Let every player role a DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check. On a success, the player overhears a rumor about the heroes they are assumed to be.

- The heroes narrowly survived the traps of an underground labyrinth. Residents of the Elemental Plane of Air are especially fearful of being underground. (In truth, it was a small dungeon with one falling net trap at the entrance.)
- The heroes defeated an elder hurricane air elemental over a grassland. (It was a summoned air elemental in the dungeon that did not want to be on the Material Plane.)
- The heroes won an airship battle over the city material plane city Neverdeep. Residents of the Elemental Plane of Air do not know Material Plane geography. (In truth, the heroes posed as laborers and snuck on a Howling Hatred's airship while it was grounded for supplies.)
- The heroes infiltrated the Howling Hatred cult's secret cloud city, riding Pegasus mounts and disguised as new recruits. They had to navigate the city's intricate maze of floating platforms while avoiding detection by the cultists. (In reality, they discovered a mountain cave where the cult had set up a safe house.)
- The heroes battled Aerisi Kalinoth atop a wizard's tower (In actuality, they defeated a low-level cult leader on the side of a mountain.)
- The heroes engaged in an aerial race upon hippogriff mounts against cultist upon giant vultures. (This did not happen.)
- Grimora Stonefist carries a vorpal long sword. (Her sword was a +1 great sword.)
- Sylva Mischiefwhistle studied at the Invisible College. (Her mentor in Calimport is barely known.)
- Thrain Ironbeard turned Acererak. (This did not happen, but he had a long history of fighting undead.)
- Aiden Shadowblade can turn invisible at will. (In actuality, he was just very sneaky.)
- Elaris Thornebow is a member of Silent Rain. (This was true.)
- Months ago, a group of mudwalker adventurers were murdered in a warehouse in the Citadel of Ice and Steel. The players' presence reminds the guests of the event. The victims were the heroes of Zephyrion.

Eager Fan Mistakes the Players for the Heroes of Zephyrion

As the players mingle with the other guests at the grand banquet, a vibrant and elegant Djinn noblewoman catches their attention. She approaches with an enchanting smile, her attire adorned with intricate patterns that shimmer with otherworldly grace. Holding a crystal wine glass, she gracefully curtsies before the players.

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"Ah, esteemed heroes," she exclaims with enthusiasm, her voice melodic and filled with excitement. "I am Lady Seraphina Windsong, and it is an absolute delight to meet you all. I couldn't contain my joy when I heard that you had successfully recovered the Scepter of Zephyrion from the Cult of Howling Hatred!"

Lady Seraphina leans in closer, her eyes sparkling with curiosity and anticipation. She eagerly begins her line of questioning.

- "Tell me, brave heroes, what was it like facing the treacherous Howling Hatred cultists? I've heard tales of their fierce elemental magic!"
- "Were there any moments during your quest that you felt your resolve waver? How did you find the strength to persevere?"
- "Did you uncover any hidden chambers or secrets within their lair? I've always been fascinated by the mysteries of dungeon delving."
- "Were there any particular artifacts or relics of elemental power that you discovered during your daring escapade? "
- "And how did you finally confront the cult's leader? I've heard whispers that they possessed a formidable airship."

Throughout the conversation, Lady Windsong takes delicate sips from her wine glass, her interest in the heroes' story palpable. The players can engage with her, whether through intimidation, deception, or persuasion, to shape the direction of the conversation and potentially uncover more about this intriguing case of mistaken identity.

- DC 10 Charisma (Deception) with advantage to claim to be the heroes who retrieved the Scepter of Zephyrion.
- DC 15 Charisma (Intimidation) to get Lady Windsong to leave the party alone.
- DC 10 Charisma (Persuasion) to get Lady Windsong to share gossip about members of the party.
- DC 10 Charisma (Persuasion) to get Lady Windsong to share rumors about the heroes who retrieved the Scepter of Zephyrion.



Drunken Son of a Noble Djinn

Aerian Stormrider is an air genasi son of a Djinn noble and has had too much wine. He will target a dwarf, or another race connected to the element of earth.

A drunk air genasi stubbles towards you, his inebriated eyes fixate on you, and a sneer curls on his lips. His words are slurred as he begins his taunts,

"Well, well, what have we here? A bunch of mudwalkers, I see. Don't you know you're in the presence of nobility? Or have you never left your wretched Material Plane?"
He sways unsteadily but continues his drunken tirade,
"You mud-dwellers can't possibly comprehend the grandeur of this place. You're like ants crawling around in the dirt, clueless and insignificant. It's a wonder you even made it this far without tripping over your own feet."

Aerian's insults are laced with arrogance and condescension as he revels in his own supposed superiority. The guests around you exchange uncomfortable glances, clearly unimpressed by his behavior.

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- DC 10 Wisdom (Insight) to deduce that the genasi is the son of a noble Djinn.
- DC 20 Charisma (Deception) to claim to be of a higher noble status on the Elemental Plane of Air than Aerian.
- DC 15 Charisma (Intimidation) to threaten Aerian into leaving the players alone.
- DC 10 Charisma (Persuasion) to deescalate the situation.
- DC 15 Charisma (Persuasion) to deescalate the situation and make Aerian into a drinking buddy.

If things go poorly, Aerian swings a punch at the players. Being drunk, Aerian is poisoned and has disadvantage on attack rolls and ability checks; use noble stats with lightning resistance. If Aerian starts losing the fight and the players do not subdue him, he will use his shocking grasp cantrip (1D8 on a melee attack with advantage against players wearing metal armor). He is too drunk to remember the rapier on his hip. Warn the players that it is a bad idea to use lethal damage against Aerian. The players are outsiders and will be immediately considered guilty of assault or murder; but everyone will blame Aerian if the players drop him with non-lethal punches.

Aerian Stormrider

Air Genasi Noble
Medium Humanoid, Neutral

Armor Class 15 (breastplate)
Hit Points 9
Speed 35 ft.
STR 11 (+0) DEX 12 (+1) CON 11 (+0) INT 12 (+1) WIS 14 (+2) CHA 16 (+3)
Skills: Deception +5, Insight +4, Persuasion +5
Senses: Passive Perception 12
Languages: Auran, Common
Challenge 1/8 (25 XP)
Proficiency Bonus +2
Resistance: lightning
Actions:
Rapier. Melee Weapon Attack: +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d8 + 1) piercing damage.
Shocking Grasp. Cantrip +2 to hit with advantage against if target is wearing metal armor, reach 5 ft., Hit: 1d8 lightning damage
Reactions:
Parry. The noble adds 2 to its AC against one melee attack that would hit it. To do so, the noble must see the attacker and wield a melee weapon.

Riddles of the Couatl

As the players mingle with the other guests at the banquet, a magnificent Couatl named Mixcoatl descends gracefully from above, its iridescent feathers shimmering like a rainbow. Mixcoatl introduces itself with a regal nod and a warm, melodious voice.

> "Esteemed heroes," Mixcoatl begins, "I am Mixcoatl, guardian of ancient knowledge and bearer of riddles. Allow me to test your wisdom and character with three riddles."

Ask three riddles if the players consent to the challenge.

Riddle 1:
"I'm not alive, but I can grow. I don't have lungs, but I need air. I don't have a mouth, but water kills me. What am I?"
Answer: (A fire)

Riddle 2:
" You hear me once and then once more. But then I die until you call like before. What am I? "
Answer: (An echo)

Riddle 3:
"Forward I am heavy, but backward, I am not. What am I?"
Answer: (The word "ton")

Each time a player gives a correct solution Mixcoatl uses an innate helpful spell on that player (player's choice); the effect lasts 24 hours.

bless, create food and water, cure wounds, lesser restoration, protection from poison, sanctuary, shield

If the players get all three riddles correct, Mixcoatl blesses every player with advantage on Wisdom saving throws for 24 hours.

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Mixcoatl - Couatl

Medium Celestial, Lawful Good
Armor Class 19 (natural armor)

Hit Points 97 (13d8 + 39)
Speed 30 ft., fly 90 ft.
STR 16 (+3) DEX 20 (+5) CON 17 (+3) INT 18 (+4) WIS 20 (+5) CHA 18 (+4)
Saving Throws CON +5, WIS +7, CHA +6
Damage Resistances Radiant
Damage Immunities Psychic; Bludgeoning, Piercing, and Slashing from Nonmagical Attacks
Senses Truesight 120 ft., Passive Perception 15
Languages All, Telepathy 120 ft.
Challenge 4 (1,100 XP)
Proficiency Bonus +2

Innate Spellcasting. The couatl's spellcasting ability is Charisma (spell save DC 14). It can innately cast the following spells, requiring only verbal components:

At will: detect evil and good, detect magic, detect thoughts

3/day each: bless, create food and water, cure wounds, lesser restoration, protection from poison, sanctuary, shield

1/day each: dream, greater restoration, scrying

Magic Weapons. The couatl's weapon attacks are magical.

Shielded Mind. The couatl is immune to scrying and to any effect that would sense its emotions, read its thoughts, or detect its location.
Actions

Bite. Melee Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. Hit: 8 (1d6 + 5) piercing damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 13 Constitution saving throw or be poisoned for 24 hours. Until this poison ends, the target is unconscious. Another creature can use an action to shake the target awake.

Constrict. Melee Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 10 ft., one Medium or smaller creature. Hit: 10 (2d6 + 3) bludgeoning damage, and the target is grappled (escape DC 15). Until this grapple ends, the target is restrained, and the couatl can't constrict another target.

Change Shape. The couatl magically polymorphs into a humanoid or beast that has a challenge rating equal to or less than its own, or back into its true form. It reverts to its true form if it dies. Any equipment it is wearing or carrying is absorbed or borne by the new form (the couatl's choice).

In a new form, the couatl retains its game statistics and ability to speak, but its AC, movement modes, Strength, Dexterity, and other actions are replaced by those of the new form, and it gains any statistics and capabilities (except class features, legendary actions, and lair actions) that the new form has but that it lacks. If the new form has a bite attack, the couatl can use its bite in that form.

Couatls are benevolent serpentine beings of great intellect and insight. Their brilliantly colored wings and gentle manner speak to their celestial origins.

Divine Caretakers. Couatls were created as guardians and caretakers by a benevolent god not worshiped since the dawn of time, and which is forgotten now by all but the couatls themselves. Most of the divine mandates given to these beings are long since fulfilled or failed. However, a few couatls still watch over ancient power, await fulfillment of prophecy, or safeguard the heirs of creatures they once guided and protected. Regardless of a couatl’s task, it prefers to remain hidden, revealing itself only as a last resort.

Truth Tellers. A couatl can’t lie, but it can withhold information, answer questions vaguely, or allow others to jump to the wrong conclusions if doing so is necessary to protect something, to keep promises, or to hide the secret of its existence.

Ancient and Few. A couatl can live for ages without sustenance, even surviving without air, but these creatures can die of disease or the passage of time. A couatl can sense its end up to a century beforehand, but it has no insight into the manner of its demise.

If a couatl has already accomplished what it set out to do, it accepts its fate. However, if its imminent death endangers the completion of its goals, it actively seeks out another couatl with which to produce offspring.

The mating ritual of couatls is a beautiful and elaborate dance of magic and light, which results in a gem-like

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egg from which a new couatl hatches. The parent that sought out the mate raises the newborn couatl and instructs it as to its duties, so that it can complete whatever task the parent leaves unfinished.

A theological discussion

The players are invited into a theological discussion with the dragonborn paladin Icescale Shieldbearer, and the aasimar cleric Aelar Skyweaver.

As you make your way through the bustling entry hall of the palace, you come across a captivating sight. Two distinguished individuals engaged in a lively and friendly theological discussion, their voices carrying a sense of deep reverence for their deities.

The first figure, standing tall and resplendent, a dragonborn. His presence exudes an aura of unwavering strength and honor, a true paladin. His scales shimmer with a metallic sheen, and a finely crafted longsword rests at his side. He nods warmly as you approach.

Beside him, radiant and graceful, stands, an aasimar cleric. His celestial heritage is evident in his ethereal features and the delicate feathers that adorn him. Aelar's robes billow gently as if moved by an invisible breeze, attesting to his connection to the goddess of elemental air. He welcomes you with a serene smile.

They focus on clerics of paladins if any are in the party. Otherwise, they focus on a player who follows a deity.

"Ah, greetings" the dragonborn says, his voice resonating with a deep, resonant timbre. "We were just discussing the intricate tapestries of faith and the ways our deities shape the world. Do you share our devotion to the divine?"

Aelar's voice is melodious and soothing as he adds, "Indeed, the mysteries of the gods are as boundless as the sky itself. We find solace in our beliefs and the guidance they offer." Engage in conversation, share your beliefs, or ask questions about Bahamut, Akadi, or any religious matters you find intriguing. The theologians are eager to engage with those who walk the path of faith.

For those with some background in religion:

- DC 5 Intelligence (Religion): You recognize Icescale's faith in Bahamut and Aelar's devotion to Akadi.
- DC 10 Intelligence (Religion): You understand their theological perspectives to a greater extent.
- DC 15 Intelligence (Nature): You impress Aelar with your understanding of Akadi's influence on weather.
- DC 15 Intelligence (Religion): You impress Icescale and Aelar with your insightful comments on religious matters.
- DC 20 Intelligence (History): You impress them by discussing the historical significance of Bahamut, Akadi, or their influence on the world.
- DC 20 Intelligence (Arcana): You captivate them with discussions about the magical aspects of their deities or the planes of existence.

For those who dare to challenge their faith:

DC 30 Intelligence (Religion): You possess such profound knowledge of religion that you manage to plant a seed of doubt in their unwavering faith.

If a player impresses one or both theologians, cast Bless as a level one spell. The blessing lasts until the end of the party or until the caster loses concentration.

Icescale Shieldbearer - Paladin of Bahamut

Medium Humanoid (Dragonborn), Lawful Good

Armor Class 18 (half plate, shield)
Hit Points 93 (11d8 + 44)
Speed 30 ft., fly 30 ft.
STR 19 (+4) DEX 13 (+1) CON 18 (+4) INT 12 (+1) WIS 14 (+2) CHA 17 (+3)
Saving Throws CON +7, INT +4, WIS +5, CHA +6
Skills Athletics +7, Perception +5, Persuasion +6
Condition Immunities Frightened
Senses Passive Perception 15

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Languages Auran, Common, Draconic
Challenge 8 (3,900 XP)
Proficiency Bonus +3

Legendary Resistance (1/Day). If the dragonborn fails a saving throw, it can choose to succeed instead.
Actions

Multiattack. The dragonborn makes three Longsword attacks.

Longsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 8 (1d8 + 4) slashing damage, or 9 (1d10 + 4) slashing damage if used with two hands, plus 13 (3d8) radiant damage. The dragonborn can cause the sword to flare with bright light, and the target must succeed on a DC 14 Constitution saving throw or be blinded until the start of the dragonborn's next turn. The sword can flare in this way only once per turn.

Healing Touch (1/Day). The dragonborn touches another creature within 5 feet of it. The target magically regains 40 hit points. In addition, all diseases and poisons affecting the target are removed.

Radiant Breath (Recharge 6). The dragonborn exhales fiery radiance in a 30-foot cone. Each creature in that area must make a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw, taking 44 (8d10) radiant damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one. When the dragonborn uses this action, it can choose up to three creatures in the cone. These creatures take no damage from the radiance and instead regain 22 (4d10) hit points each.



Aelar Skyweaver - Aasimar Cleric of Akadi

Medium Humanoid (Angel), Neutral

Armor Class 12
Hit Points 5 (10d8 + 63)
Speed 30 ft., fly 60 ft.
STR 8 (-1) DEX 15 (+2) CON 13 (+1) INT 16 (+3) WIS 16 (+3) CHA 14 (+2)
Saving Throws WIS +7, CHA +6
Damage Resistances Necrotic, Radiant
Senses Passive Perception 13
Languages Auran, Celestial, Common, Draconic, Elvish
Challenge 10 (5,900 XP)
Proficiency Bonus +4

Join the Band

As you mingle with the other guests in the entry hall of the palace, the enchanting melodies of an air elemental band waft through the air, their ethereal music resonating with the essence of the Elemental Plane of Air. The musicians themselves are barely visible, their forms appearing as swirling gusts of wind, and their instruments float gracefully near them.

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The band consists of a group of wind elementals playing an array of wind instruments, such as flutes, panpipes, and other harmonic wind creations. The ethereal music they produce is captivating, filling the hall with an otherworldly atmosphere.

However, as you listen, you notice a unique opportunity. Among the floating instruments, there's one vacant spot, an unused instrument seemingly waiting for a skilled musician to join the ensemble. If you are proficient with musical instruments, this is your chance to become part of the air elemental band and contribute to the enchanting performance.

- DC 5 Charisma (Performance): You can play a back-up role, harmonizing with the wind elementals and adding depth to their music.
- DC 10 Charisma (Performance): You manage to impress the air elementals enough to contribute to the main melody and rhythm of their performance.
- DC 15 Charisma (Performance): Your musical prowess shines as you take on a leading role within the band, guiding the ensemble's performance with your skillful playing.
- DC 20 Charisma (Performance): Your talent is so extraordinary that the air elemental band stops playing to listen in awe as you perform a mesmerizing solo piece, leaving the entire hall captivated.

If the player is successful, the player has +1 DC on bardic magic for 24 hours.

- On a failed role the player receives dirty looks and the guest make snide remarks such as "tone deaf mudwalkers." The player feels peer pressure to step down.
- On a role of natural 1, security takes the instrument and politely escorts the player off the stage.

A dance off

Amidst the lively atmosphere of the hall, you see a spirited dance competition taking place. Guests have gathered on the grand dance floor, showing off their dance skills to outshine one another. As you watch, a graceful and elegant female djinn catches your eye. She exudes an air of confidence and silently challenges you and your companions to a dance-off.

She specifically challenges athletic or agile players.

Each participant can choose to use either their Strength (Athletics), Dexterity (Acrobatics), or Charisma (Persuasion) to demonstrate their dance skills. The djinn herself relies on her natural charisma to sway the crowd. Players that have a background as a dancer performer has advantage on their roll.

Players using Strength (Athletics), Dexterity (Acrobatics), or Charisma (Persuasion) make opposed rolls against the Djinn's +5 Charisma (Persuasion) rolls.

If a player succeeds in the dance-off, they impress the crowd and gain an advantage on the skill they used for the remainder of the banquet. Your dance moves become the talk of the evening, earning you respect and admiration from the other guests.

The dance competition unfolds with enthusiasm, each participant showcasing their unique style and flair. The music's rhythm pulses through your veins as you engage in this friendly competition, all while the other guests watch with anticipation.

Azurith Arrives

As the guests mingle and enjoy the melodies of the air elemental band, a hushed and expectant silence gradually descended upon the grand hall. The vibrant colors of the guests' attire and the faint scents of a myriad of perfumes filled the air, creating an atmosphere of opulence and elegance.

Amidst this anticipation, a regal figure emerged at the top of a grand staircase, slowly descending with an aura of dignified grace. Azurith, the host of the banquet and master of the palace, makes his grand entrance.

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Azurith, a Djinni of immense stature, appeared before his esteemed guests. His form radiated a soft, cerulean glow, and his attire resembled flowing robes that seemed woven from the very air itself. He does not step, but hovers as he descends towards the guest. In his right hand, he holds a magical scepter as a walking staff.

As Azurith reached the bottom of the staircase, he raises his scepter high above his head, and a gentle gust of wind swirled around him. He speaks in the melodious and breathy tones of Auran, the native language of the Elemental Plane of Air.

Azurith's voice echoed throughout the hall. "My esteemed guests. Tonight, we gather beneath the boundless skies to celebrate unity, culture, and the enduring spirit of the elemental realms."

The guests, their attention fully captured by Azurith's presence, responded in kind, echoing words of greeting and admiration in Auran. With a radiant smile, Azurith gestured toward the grand dining room beyond, inviting everyone to continue the evening's festivities.

With Azurith leading the way, the guests make their way into the opulent dining room, where an intricately designed seating arrangement awaited them. The seating arrangement reflects the social status within the Citadel of Ice and Steel.

The players, although present and honored guests, find themselves seated together in a lesser-status location. The staff, dressed in their formal attire, graciously assist guests in finding their designated seats, ensuring that every detail was meticulously attended to.

If players try to reveal that they are not the heroes, guests and staff are puzzled but do not contradict the players. If the players talk with Azurith, he does not realize that they are not the heroes and sincerely laughs at the idea that the players are not the heroes. If the players convince him in front of other guests, he is deeply embarrassed and quietly has security escort the players to a coach.

Azurith - Noble Djinn

Large Elemental, Chaotic Good

Armor Class 17 (natural armor)
Hit Points 161 (14d10 + 84)
Speed 30 ft., fly 90 ft.
STR 21 (+5) DEX 15 (+2) CON 22 (+6) INT 15 (+2) WIS 16 (+3) CHA 20 (+5)
Saving Throws DEX +6, WIS +7, CHA +9
Damage Immunities Lightning, Thunder
Senses Darkvision 120 ft., Passive Perception 13
Languages Auran
Challenge 11 (7,200 XP)
Proficiency Bonus +4

Elemental Demise. If the djinni dies, its body disintegrates into a warm breeze, leaving behind only equipment the djinni was wearing or carrying.

Innate Spellcasting. The djinni's innate spellcasting ability is Charisma (spell save DC 17, +9 to hit with spell attacks). It can innately cast the following spells, requiring no material components:

At will: detect evil and good, detect magic, thunderwave

3/day each: create food and water (can create wine instead of water) , tongues, wind walk

1/day each: conjure elemental (air elemental only), creation, gaseous form, invisibility, major image, plane shift
Actions

Multiattack. The djinni makes three scimitar attacks.

Scimitar. Melee Weapon Attack: +9 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 12 (2d6 + 5) slashing damage plus 3 (1d6) lightning or thunder damage (djinni's choice).

Create Whirlwind. A 5-foot-radius, 30-foot-tall cylinder of swirling air magically forms on a point the djinni can see within 120 feet of it. The whirlwind lasts if the djinni maintains concentration (as if concentrating on a spell). Any creature but the djinni that enters the whirlwind must succeed on a DC 18 Strength saving throw or be restrained by it. The djinni can move the whirlwind up to 60 feet as an action, and creatures restrained by the whirlwind move with it. The whirlwind ends if the djinni loses sight of it.

A creature can use its action to free a creature restrained by the whirlwind, including itself, by succeeding on a DC 18 Strength check. If the check

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succeeds, the creature is no longer restrained and moves to the nearest space outside the whirlwind.

Zephyrus' Deception

After the main course, just as the anticipation for dessert builds, Zephyrus discreetly approaches the players' seats.

"My dear friends," he begins, leaning in with a hushed tone, "I find myself in need of your heroics once more. Alas, the details cannot be shared openly. Please, follow me."

- A DC 10 Wisdom (Insight) check might reveal that Zephyrus appears nervous, clearly wishing to keep this conversation hidden from Azurith's prying eyes.
- A DC 20 Wisdom (Insight) check uncovers that Zephyrus is lying.

With a courteous gesture, Zephyrus leads the players towards the wine cellar entrance, holding the door ajar with a smile. As the last player steps inside, the door is slammed shut, and the latch clicks ominously.

Zephyrus bribed five kenku groundskeepers to kill the players. The kenku plan to murder the players, take their belongings, and throw the bodies off the earth mote. The kenku menace their prey by mimicking gruesome stabbing sounds. Two of them attack with short swords and three attack with short bows while lurking behind half cover.

The characters are surprised if they walk into the ambush. The cellar door cannot be unlocked from the inside and has an AC of 15 and 18 hit points.

Zephyrus - Aarakocra Commoner

Medium Humanoid (Aarakocra), Neutral Good

Armor Class 12
Hit Points 13 (3d8)
Speed 20 ft., fly 50 ft.
STR 10 (+0) DEX 14 (+2) CON 10 (+0) INT 11 (+0) WIS 12 (+1) CHA 11 (+0)
Skills Perception +5
Senses Passive Perception 15
Languages Aarakocra, Auran
Challenge 1/4 (50 XP)
Proficiency Bonus +2

Dive Attack. If the aarakocra is flying and dives at least 30 feet straight toward a target and then hits it with a melee weapon attack, the attack deals an extra 3 (1d6) damage to the target.
Actions

Talon. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 4 (1d4 + 2) slashing damage.

Kenku

Medium Humanoid (Kenku), Chaotic Neutral

Armor Class 13
Hit Points 13 (3d8)
Speed 30 ft.
STR 10 (+0) DEX 16 (+3) CON 10 (+0) INT 11 (+0) WIS 10 (+0) CHA 10 (+0)
Skills Deception +4, Perception +2, Stealth +5
Senses Passive Perception 12
Languages understands Auran and Common but speaks only through the use of its Mimicry trait
Challenge 1/4 (50 XP)
Proficiency Bonus +2

Ambusher. In the first round of combat, the kenku has advantage on attack rolls against any creature it surprised.

Mimicry. The kenku can mimic any sounds it has heard, including voices. A creature that hears the sounds can tell they are imitations with a successful DC 14 Wisdom (Insight) check.
Actions

Shortsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 6 (1d6 + 3) piercing damage.

Shortbow. Ranged Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, range 80/320 ft., one target. Hit: 6 (1d6 + 3) piercing damage.

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Kenku are feathered humanoids that wander the world as vagabonds, driven by greed. They can perfectly imitate any sound they hear.

Fallen Flocks. Kenku wear ill-fitting cloaks, robes, and rags. These garments cover the soft, sleek feathers of their bodies, shrouding their bare arms and legs. They tread lightly when they walk, on talons made for grasping the branches of trees and seizing prey from the lofty skies. Soft as the wind they move, so as not to draw attention to their shameful forms.

Once, the kenku held the wind in their wings, embracing the gusty sky and singing the sweet language of birdsong. Serving a master whose identity is now lost to their memory, the kenku coveted the glittering baubles of his household, and longed to speak so that they could cajole and swindle others out of such treasures. Stealing the secret of speech from a volume in their master's library, they disguised themselves in rags to beg for pretty things. When their master learned of their greed, he stripped away their wings as punishment, forcing them to beg forever.

Speech in Pantomime. Kenku can mimic the sound of anything they hear. A kenku asking for money might make the sound of coins clinking together, and a kenku referring to a busy marketplace can reproduce the cacophony of hawking vendors, barking dogs, bleating sheep, and the cries of street urchins. When mimicking voices, they can only repeat words and phrases they have heard, not create new sentences. To converse with a kenku is to witness a performance of imitated sounds and almost nonsensical verse.

Kenku speak to one another in much the same way. Because they are adept at interpreting one another's glances and gestures, the sounds they make to communicate complex ideas or emotions can be succinct. Groups of kenku also develop secret codes. For example, a cat's meow might be the secret code for "Prepare to attack!" or "Flee for your lives!"

Their talent for mimicry extends to handwriting, and criminal organizations often employ kenku to forge documents. When a kenku commits a crime, it might forge evidence to implicate another creature.

The Wistful Wingless. All kenku pine for the ability to fly, and thus the punishments they mete out to one another often involve false wings, such as heavy wings of wood borne as a mark of shame. As a final, tragic reminder of the wings they once had, kenku carry out executions by hurling their condemned from tall buildings or cliffs.



After the ambush

Amidst the cacophony of the banquet, the battle remained concealed, a clandestine affair known only to Zephyrus and the players.

If the players opt for an immediate departure, a waiting coach standing ready to return guests to the Citadel whisks them away to the main gate.

If the players make the battle know to the banquet hall or make a ruckus that disturbs the meal, Azurith sends security to investigate.

At first Azurith and the guest assume that the mudwalking players are to blame. At Azurith's first line of questions towards him, Zephyrus breaks down, throws himself at his master's feet too ashamed to look up. Through sobs Zephyrus reveals his deception of the players and his role in the theft of the Scepter of Zephyrion.

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Zephyrus was a beloved servant. Azurith with tears in his eyes orders his security to chain Zephyrus and throw him off the earth mote to fall to his death or for eternity.

Azurith does not like having the incident in front of guests. He turns to the players and orders

"Heroes," he addresses them, "your mission now is to seek out and eliminate the remaining cultists within the citadel. Each of you shall be rewarded with 75 gold coins. Go forth swiftly!"

In this city governed by strict laws, Azurith is keenly aware of the potential repercussions if his own forces provoke disturbances. Thus, he strategically employs the players to resolve his predicament, reestablishing his reputation without having to soil his own hands.

Through his sobs Zephyrus described the Howling Hatred's hideout and its location. The coach driver will take the players to the main gate, through the Thunderbolt check points, and to the neighborhood of the hideout. For her own safety the driver will not bring the carriage close to the hideout.

Finding the hideout

The players may take a short rest while traveling to the Citadel of Ice and Steel.

As your floating carriage, pulled by magnificent griffons, approaches the imposing main gate of the Citadel of Ice and Steel, you're greeted by a breathtaking sight. The citadel itself is a massive, aerodynamic structure, built upon a colossal glacial rock that perpetually hurtles through the gulf of Elemental Air, creating a continuous rush of wind throughout the streets. The palace of the Great Caliph of the Djinn stands as a testament to both its power and mobility.

As your carriage hovers before the gate, you can feel the powerful currents of the Elemental Plane of Air swirling around you. The driver, a seasoned and confident individual, skillfully maneuvers the carriage closer to the gate.

Two Thunderbolt guards, clad in azure armor with bolts of lightning adorning their helmets, approach your carriage as it comes to a halt. Their eyes, sharp and vigilant, scan the carriage and its passengers.

The driver, showing great respect, speaks to the guards in Auran, "Honorable Thunderbolts, we seek passage into the Citadel of Ice and Steel, at the behest of Azurith."

One of the guards' nods, his expression stern. "State your purpose and the nature of your visit."

With a calm and steady tone, the driver replies, "We are here on a mission concerning the murder of the mudwalkers several months ago. We seek to enter and fulfill our duties as swiftly as possible."

After a brief exchange of whispered words between the guards, the one who spoke earlier turns to you, "Very well, you may proceed. Do not stray from the designated path. The Citadel is a place of law and order, and any disruptions will be dealt with severely."

Your carriage is allowed to pass through the gate, and as it glides through the streets of the Citadel of Ice and Steel, you can't help but be captivated by the grandeur of this elemental city. The architecture seems to defy gravity itself, with structures suspended in perpetual freefall.

Finally, the driver brings your carriage to a stop in a quiet neighborhood. He gestures toward a nondescript street. "This is where we part ways. I do not wish to engage the Howling Hatred. This is the neighborhood Zephyrus spoke of. I will wait at Azurith's palace. Any Thunderbolt will send word for me to retrieve you."

With that, the driver bids you farewell, and you step out of the carriage, ready to continue your quest to uncover the Howling Hatred cult.

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Have the players one-by-one role DC 20 Intelligence (Investigation) checks to find the Howling Hatred hideout. Characters who know thieves' cant or encountered the Howling Hatred's symbol in previous adventures role with advantage.

The players will know they found the warehouse when they spot the Howling Hatred's symbol in a discreet location on the building.

Every time a player fails the Intelligence (Investigation) check, role or select an encounter.

1. Suspicious Informant: The players encounter a mysterious air genasi who claims to have information they want to know. She will give the information for 50 gp. She is a 4th level Inquisitive Rogue and decerned that the players are looking for something. She does not know about the Howling Hatred, nor what the players are looking for; this is a con. If the characters pay, she will point down a road and tell them to "Go half a mile and turn left, it will be on your right."

- DC 14 Wisdom (Insight) to spot that this is a con.
- DC 15 Charisma (Persuasion) or Charisma (Intimidation) to reduce the price to 25gp.

2. Sudden Gust of Wind: A gust of wind blasts the players backwards. The effect is equal to level 1 casting of the spell of the same name. Each player must role a DC 15 Strength check or be pushed back 15 feet.
3. Lightning Strike: A cloud rapidly forms a few feet above the characters and lightning randomly strikes a player. The target must roll a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw; the roll is with disadvantage if the target is wearing metal armor. On a failed roll the players take 1d8, and half on a success.
4. Street Performers: A group of air elemental street performers captivates the players with their mesmerizing performance. The players may join in the performance or dance using the rules presented during the banquet.
5. Street Fight: The players stumble upon a street fight between a drunk djinn and an air elemental. Both brawlers are using non-lethal combat, and the fight is over a petty squabble.
6. Lost Child: A lost air genasi child approaches the players, asking for help in finding their parents. The child is clearly alone, scared and only speaks Auran.
7. Hidden Messages: The players discover Howling Hatred graffiti. The tags include the symbol on the warehouse that the players are looking for. The characters role with advantage on their Intelligence (Investigation) checks from not on.
8. False Leads: The players receive a tip from an aarakocra that they one they are looking for is down an alley. If the players follow the tip, they find a homeless aarakocra passed out from drinking too much.
9. Elemental Obstacle: A huge hurricane air elemental and a storm giant are having a lively conversation in the players' path. The characters need to find a way around the strong winds.
10. Beggar's Plea: A beggar approaches the players, begging for food or coins. The beggar knows where the Howling Hatred are hiding, but does not know the players are looking for the cult and will not give the information unless they first gave food or coin.
11. Street Merchant: A street merchant that will not take no for an answer harasses the players to buy her mundane supplies. She will stand in their way, take their hat, grab their arm etc. The items are low to average quality.
12. Pets on the run: An aarakorca tending a noble djinn's pet elementals loses control of the pets. The two pets are tiny in size and the aarakorca begs the players to help catch them.

The Howling Hatred's Hideout

The symbol of the Howling Hatred, serving as a hidden marker for the cult's warehouse hideout, is discreetly etched into a spot where the foundation is exposed. It blends with the natural wear and tear of the structure. Its faded appearance and position close to the street makes it virtually invisible to flying passersby.

The warehouse itself appears quite unremarkable from the outside, blending in with the other buildings in the neighborhood. It is a two-story, rectangular structure constructed primarily of cold, gray cloudstone, giving it a rather drab and industrial appearance.

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The exterior walls are made of sturdy, rough-hewn cloudstone blocks, cold to the touch even in the windy climate of the Citadel. Darkened with age, they seem to absorb the very essence of the city.

The building has no windows on the ground level, and the ones that exist are small and high up. The second floor, however, has windows that are all heavily curtained from the inside, obscuring any view into the building.

The main entrance is a thick wooden door reinforced with iron bands. It appears to have seen better days and might have once been grand, but it now stands worn and slightly askew on its hinges.

The building's only noticeable feature is a faded and illegible sign hanging from a rusted iron bracket near the entrance. It seems to have been intentionally neglected and left to decay.

The most straightforward way is through the main entrance. The heavy wooden door, while aged, remains sturdy and can be opened with effort.

- AC 15, Hit points 18
- DC 15 to pick the lock with thieves' tools.

On the side of the warehouse, there are large cargo loading doors, which are padlocked from the outside.

- The chain has 10 hit points. It will break with a successful DC 20 Strength check.
- DC 15 to pick the lock with thieves' tools.

The flat roof of the warehouse features a few skylights made of translucent ice.

- DC 10 Strength (Athletics) or Dexterity (Acrobatics) to climb onto the roof.
- AC 13, Hit points 5

There is also a concealed rear door, accessible through a narrow alleyway, which is hidden behind a stack of crates. The entrance is cleverly disguised.

- DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) to find the door if looking for a hidden entrance.
- DC 20 Wisdom (Perception) to spot the door without actively looking.

The Howling Hatred does not know that the players are on their trail. If the players are sneaky, they can get the upper hand on the cultist inside. If the players announce themselves or break-in, the cultists prepare to fight.

Inside the warehouse, there is one cult fanatic and one cultist for each member of the party, all of whom are air genasi. The cultists fight with scimitars or shocking grasp. The cult fanatic cast spells targeting magic users first.

- She casts spiritual weapon first (before initiative if she knows the players are coming).
- Then she uses hold person, recasting if she loses concentration.
- Then uses command to force players to flee while the cultists cut down other players.
- If last cultist standing, she uses inflict wounds.
- She uses sacred flame, shocking grasp, or multiattack with her dagger after running out of spell slots.

The warehouse is a hollow space within an otherwise unassuming building. The air inside is cold and carries a faint scent of dampness.

The central area of the hideout is an open space with a high ceiling, supported by thick cloudstone pillars that stretch from floor to top. The walls are rough-hewn cloudstone blocks, giving the chamber an industrial and foreboding atmosphere.

Against one wall, you notice a makeshift altar to Yan-C-Bin made from stacked crates covered with a tattered blue and white cloth. Upon it, there are scattered remnants of offerings: small trinkets, feathers, and the Howling Hatred's symbol etched onto stones. At the center of the altar, a low-burning incense brazier releases fragrant smoke that fills the room with an otherworldly aroma.

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To one side of the chamber, crates and barrels are stacked haphazardly, creating a makeshift storage area. These crates contain supplies and provisions, including dried rations, water skins, and Howling Hatred masks used in rituals.

In a corner of the chamber, you spot a sleeping area. Simple, worn bedding lies on the ground, with personal belongings strewn about. The cultists have been living here for some time, as evidenced by the scattered clothing and a few personal effects.

Against one wall, a wooden bookshelf contains a collection of ancient tomes, scrolls, and weathered books. These materials seem to be related to elemental magic and air-based spells. They're dust-covered, suggesting they haven't been touched in a while.

There is a potion of lightning resistance, a scroll of feather fall, and a scroll of gust of wind.

A concealed trapdoor in the corner of the chamber leads to a lower level.

Players who use the trapdoor discover the cult fanatic's private quarters. As they search through the small, cramped room, they stumble upon a series of letters exchanged between the Howling Hatred and a lesser-known illusionist known as Elara Shadewind from the Invisible College. These correspondences reveal that Elara has been an informant for the cult for at least two years, sharing critical information about the Scepter of Zephyrion and actively aiding the Howling Hatred.

Among the fanatic's notes, they come across Elara Shadewind's residential address. The party can either take the evidence to the authorities or confront the illusionist directly.

The Thunderbolts, the city's law enforcement, harbor mixed feelings about the players' actions. While they are concerned about the increasing violence, they also recognize the threat posed by the Howling Hatred sect within the Citadel of Ice and Steel. As a result, they are willing to let the players take on the dangerous task of dealing with the cult, albeit with some reservations.

Cult Fanatic

Medium Air- Genasi, Neutral Evil

Armor Class 13 (leather armor)
Hit Points 33 (6d8 + 6)
Speed 30 ft.
STR 11 (+0) DEX 14 (+2) CON 12 (+1) INT 10 (+0) WIS 13 (+1) CHA 14 (+2)
Skills Deception +4, Persuasion +4, Religion +2
Senses Passive Perception 11
Languages Any one language (usually Common)
Challenge 2 (450 XP)
Proficiency Bonus +2

Dark Devotion. The fanatic has advantage on saving throws against being charmed or frightened.

Spellcasting. The fanatic is a 4th-level spellcaster. Its spellcasting ability is Wisdom (spell save DC 11, +3 to hit with spell attacks). The fanatic has the following cleric spells prepared:

Cantrips (at will): light, sacred flame, thaumaturgy

1st level (4 slots): command, inflict wounds, shield of faith

2nd level (3 slots): hold person, spiritual weapon
Actions

Multiattack. The fanatic makes two melee attacks.

Dagger. Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one creature. Hit: 4 (1d4 + 2) piercing damage.
Description

Fanatics are often part of a cult's leadership, using their charisma and dogma to influence and prey on those of weak will. Most are interested in personal power above all else.

Cultist

Medium Air- Genasi, Neutral Evil

Armor Class 12 (leather armor)
Hit Points 9 (2d8)
Speed 30 ft.
STR 11 (+0) DEX 12 (+1) CON 10 (+0) INT 10 (+0) WIS 11 (+0) CHA 10 (+0)
Skills Deception +2, Religion +2
Senses Passive Perception 10

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Languages Any one language (usually Common)
Challenge 1/8 (25 XP)
Proficiency Bonus +2

Dark Devotion. The cultist has advantage on saving throws against being charmed or frightened.
Actions

Scimitar. Melee Weapon Attack: +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. Hit: 4 (1d6 + 1) slashing damage.
Description

Cultists swear allegiance to dark powers such as elemental princes, demon lords, or archdevils. Most conceal their loyalties to avoid being ostracized, imprisoned, or executed for their beliefs.

Confronting Shadewind

Elara Shadewind currently resides at her villa, situated near the center of the Citadel of Ice and Steel. The villa's entrance gates are protected by alarm spells, serving as a warning system for any unwanted visitors. Moreover, the backdoor and windows are inscribed with glyph of warding spells. All entrances to her villa are unlocked.

Within the villa, Elara has several smoke mephits to defend her. Each of these corresponds to one of the players, with two additional mephits.

Elara's preferred strategy is to cast invisibility upon herself and attempt a discreet escape from the situation. She prefers avoiding direct confrontation if possible. However, if pressed into battle, she will unleash her magic.

Her initial choice is to cast phantasmal killer, targeting either a magic user within the group or the most menacing player present.

Additionally, Elara has a trick up her sleeve – the ability to conjure a major illusion. She will likely try to trick the players with a cloudstone wall. This is intended to redirect the players towards combating her mephits.

Should the battle persist, Elara will utilize her higher-level spell slots to cast magic missile. If things become dire, she'll resort to poison spray as a ranged option, and in the most desperate of situations, she'll wield her quarterstaff in melee combat.

Elara is wearing a ring of jumping. Her home contains a spellbook with the following spells.

color spray, disguise self, mage armor, magic missile, invisibility, mirror image, phantasmal force, major image, phantom steed, phantasmal killer

After the battle the Thunderbolts arrive and assume the players are malicious felons. The Thunderbolt officers will look the other way if the players present their evidence of Elara's connection to the Howling Hatred. Letters and notes found in her study will collaborate the player's claims.

Illusionist

Medium Human, Neutral Evil

Armor Class 12 (15 with mage armor)
Hit Points 38 (7d8 + 7)
Speed 30 ft.
STR 9 (-1) DEX 14 (+2) CON 13 (+1) INT 16 (+3) WIS 11 (+0) CHA 12 (+1)
Saving Throws INT +5, WIS +2
Skills Arcana +5, History +5
Senses Passive Perception 10
Languages any four languages
Challenge 3 (700 XP)
Proficiency Bonus +2

Spellcasting. The illusionist is a 7th-level spellcaster. Its spellcasting ability is Intelligence (spell save DC 13, +5 to hit with spell attacks). The illusionist has the following wizard spells prepared:

Cantrips (at will): dancing lights, mage hand, minor illusion, poison spray

1st level (4 slots): color spray,* disguise self,* mage armor, magic missile

2nd level (3 slots): invisibility,* mirror image,* phantasmal force*

3rd level (3 slots): major image,* phantom steed*

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4th level (1 slot): phantasmal killer*

*Illusion spell of 1st level or higher

Displacement (Recharges after the Illusionist Casts an Illusion Spell of 1st Level or Higher). As a bonus action, the illusionist projects an illusion that makes the illusionist appear to be standing in a place a few inches from its actual location, causing any creature to have disadvantage on attack rolls against the illusionist. The effect ends if the illusionist takes damage, it is incapacitated, or its speed becomes 0.
Actions

Quarterstaff. Melee Weapon Attack: +1 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 2 (1d6 - 1) bludgeoning damage, or 3 (1d8 - 1) bludgeoning damage if used with two hands.

Illusionists are specialist wizards who twist light, sound, shadow, and even minds to create false and quasi-real effects. They can be flamboyant and use their powers in spectacular and obvious ways, or quiet and subtle, using their magic to conceal the truth.



Smoke Mephit

Small Elemental, Neutral Evil

Armor Class 12
Hit Points 22 (5d6 + 5)
Speed 30 ft., fly 30 ft.
STR 6 (-2) DEX 14 (+2) CON 12 (+1) INT 10 (+0) WIS 10 (+0) CHA 11 (+0)
Skills Perception +2, Stealth +4
Damage Immunities Fire, Poison
Condition Immunities Poisoned
Senses Darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 12
Languages Auran, Ignan
Challenge 1/4 (50 XP)
Proficiency Bonus +2

Death Burst. When the mephit dies, it leaves behind a cloud of smoke that fills a 5-foot-radius sphere centered on its space. The sphere is heavily obscured. Wind disperses the cloud, which otherwise lasts for 1 minute.

Innate Spellcasting (1/Day). The mephit can innately cast dancing lights, requiring no material components. Its innate spellcasting ability is Charisma.
Actions

Claws. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. Hit: 4 (1d4 + 2) slashing damage.

Cinder Breath (Recharge 6). The mephit exhales a 15-foot cone of smoldering ash. Each creature in that area must succeed on a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw or be blinded until the end of the mephit's next turn.

Smoke mephits are crude, lazy creatures of air and fire that billow smoke constantly. They rarely speak the truth and love to mock and mislead other creatures.

Aftermath

If the players cleared out the Howling Hatred hideout, Azurith gives them each the promised gold. If the players report Elara Shadewind to him without confronting her or if she escaped, Azurith is very concerned that a member of the Invisible College worked for the Howling Hatred. Azurith uses his influence to have the Thunderbolts investigate the

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matter. If the players defeated Elara, Azurith congratulates them, has a bard write a song about the tale, and throws a banquet in their honor, but does not increase the reward.

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